

Editorial

Dear Readers,

Writing this editorial was a pleasure for two reasons.

The first, I wrote it while travelling on the Delhi metro's newly opened route that connects South Delhi to Gurgaon (a suburb of Delhi, where I live). While the metro route has not, as yet, grown to the extent of connecting our office (at Okhla) to my residence, that did not stop me from getting down mid-way and checking out this new mode of transport, which promises to make the National Capital Region (Delhi and its suburbs) a better place to live in. I have ridden on the Delhi metro before; the joy of sitting on a train that takes you home... that's hard to put into words.

The second reason to feel good was my trip to Kerala. Now, before you wonder whether I am going to use all this space to write a travelogue, let me reassure you that the Kerala trip was all about Linux and open source. I was invited by UNESCO to attend a conference on 'Software for the Public Sector, with a Focus on Public Education', where open source was at the centre of the discussion.

We've covered many case studies and success stories in *LINUX For You*, but I believe, to date, I witnessed the best implementation of Linux and open source at Kerala. While most Indian states have opted to outsource computer training to external agencies like Educamp, Kerala's education department has opted to train its existing set of teachers on how to use computers and, more importantly, on how to use computers to teach better. And, while they were at it, they introduced open source as their platform of choice for the entire computerisation initiative.

Kerala's Department of Education produces its own distro customised to impart school education. Besides Ubuntu-based Linux, the distro is bundled with a lot of open source applications for school education, such as Marble, GeoGebra, Sun Clock, etc. Many of these apps have been customised by a panel of teachers to suit their curriculum and their audience. The entire system works like an open source community. Each school has some identified computer expert(s), referred to as master trainers, who network under the IT@School umbrella. They review new software, update the distro with what works, removing what does not, and then train teachers on the new software that has been introduced. A brilliant example of an in-house driven 'train-the-trainer' initiative.

While there's no doubt that the school teachers and even their political bosses have a significant role to play here, the driving force behind this success story is the duo, Mohammad Hanish and Anwar Sadath. The former is a senior IAS officer with the designation of director,

Kerala Education Board, while the latter is the executive director of IT@Schools—the organisation that powers this entire initiative. As per the organisational chart, I believe Mr Sadath reports to Mr Hanish, but their chemistry was like that of two friends having a great time, showcasing the results of their hard work. I am sure it's the open source bug that's to be blamed for behaviour that's in total contrast to some of the glum and serious faces one sees in the higher ranks of the government departments at Delhi.

The bottom line? Kerala has become a state where (government) school teachers know how to use open source software. Students are learning open source software while still in school. Thus, the future generations of this state are poised to be open source savvy—a skill-set many organisations would pay a premium for. This is because the combination of the mind-set and the skill sets of someone who's become comfortable with open source is not only going to mean lower expenditure on software but also an ability to try something new, and learn from it.

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Oops! My station has been announced. Time to get off. But one passing thought before I shut down my laptop—there seems to be a lot of positive energy all around us, whether it's on the faces of youngsters sitting next to me who are also discovering the wonders of the metro, or that of the teachers in Kerala who proudly shared their experiences with open source. Touch wood!

Best wishes,



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PS: A detailed report on Kerala's tryst with open source awaits you in the next issue of LFY.